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British Defence Policy after the Falklands

BRUCE GEORGE, MP AND MICHAEL COUGHLIN

The military conflict between Britain and Argentina that began on 2 April 1982 with Argentinian forces entering Port Stanley, and ended on 14 June 1982 with the successful assault by British troops, has already had a significant effect on domestic politics, on the relationship between Britain and her allies, and on the foreign policy of her principal ally, the United States. These and other important topics will be outside the scope of this brief paper which will concentrate on the military lessons to be learned from the 'war' and on the potential consequences for British defence policy in the decade ahead.

That there are important lessons to be learned is undeniable even though the warfare was limited, distant, and some argue, almost of the nineteenth century in certain respects. Much of what has been said and written since the crisis began three months ago is based on incomplete or incorrect information. Many analysts, politicians and military men throughout the world will be gathering information for sifting and analysing. Already a team of operational analysts and weapons experts have been dispatched, and John Nott, Secretary of State for Defence, has indicated that there will be an inquiry lasting approximately four months culminating in the publication of recommendations in a White Paper and, it is hoped, in the swift implementation of appropriate actions.

The Prime Minister, Mrs Thatcher, has announced an inquiry, to be chaired by Lord Franks and senior Members of Parliament, into the controversial events leading up to the invasion. The exact format is not known at time of writing (25 June 1982), but we do know that Mrs Thatcher is anxious to broaden the inquiry to include the Falklands policies of previous governments as well.

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There are also to be separate naval inquiries into the sinking of the individual ships.

The Defence Committee of the House of Commons, established in 1979 and consisting of eleven backbench MPs, decided shortly after the Task Force set sail that it would inquire into 'the state of readiness of HM Forces and the dispositions made up to 2 April, and military operations consequent upon those dispositions.' This subsequently has been broadened and will encompass the controversial MoD relations with the media.[1]

The inquiry will begin on 20 July and no doubt the various investigations, particularly the MoD's own inquiry, will yield much of relevance as well as provide another opportunity for special pleading by the individual services. The conflict in and around the Falklands has reopened the debate on the future defence position of Britain which John Nott had hoped to settle in his paper 'The United Kingdom Defence Programme; The Way Forward' of June last year. The conflict may thus prove significant in the post-war evolution of British defence and foreign policy, and may have considerable bearing on future directions.

Military Implications

Analysis of the military consequences of the Falkland Islands reveals a lack of clear consensus among the experts. Indeed, there appears to be a 'something-for-everyone' mentality emerging. Everyone seems to be claiming that the conflict in the South Atlantic vindicates his line of strategic thought. For example, in the current US debate on the size of aircraft carriers, Navy Secretary John Lehman believes that the US Navy should construct two additional *Nimitz*-class carriers, citing the British deficiency in long-range air power as the major reason for her losses at sea; but opponents, including Senator Gary Hart, point to the vulnerability of large ships, quipping that Lehman's new carriers should be christened the USS *Sheffield* and the USS *Belgrano*.[2] To a degree the Falklands have vindicated both, but until more data emerges and the 'experts' are willing to form a more objective view of the conflict than that which reflects their parochial pre-war trends of thought, there is little hope of ascertaining the real lessons of the Falklands. The first step towards such an end is identifying the issues which should be analysed.

Surface ships and fleet defence

World-wide attention was focused on this first naval confrontation since World War II, and one in which the arsenals of the electronic age were tested. The most publicized action was the sinking of HMS *Sheffield* by a French-built *Exocet* missile fired by a French-built *Super Etendard*. The effectiveness of this air-launched version, which also sank the container ship *Atlantic Conveyor*, and its land-based version, which severely damaged HMS *Glamorgan*, underscores the vulnerability of surface ships. However, many armchair admirals have prematurely condemned the effectiveness of the British surface ships and their weapons systems, for one must remember that both the ships and weapons systems were designed primarily for anti-submarine warfare in the North Atlantic and not for support in amphibious operations. The air defence systems were supposed to act in concert with land-based aircraft. The medium-range anti-aircraft and anti-missile system *Sea Dart*, which is designed to counter medium and high level threats, was effective in preventing aircraft from attacking targets from high altitudes and from launching long-range stand-off missiles. According to Secretary Nott, *Sea Dart* was the naval missile system which downed the largest number of Argentinian aircraft. Aircraft that evaded the *Harrier* patrols and faced an effective medium SAM system made their attacks from low level to avoid radar detection. The loss of HMS *Sheffield* might have had nothing to do with the effectiveness of *Sea Dart*, as it appears that the attack occurred when the ship's radar was switched off in order to operate a satellite communication system. If the radar had been on, it is conceivable that the HMS *Sheffield* could have downed the attacking aircraft before the deadly cargo was launched. Despite *Sea Dart*'s effectiveness, it did have many operational deficiencies. One correspondent stated that *Sea Dart* was Britain's greatest threat to low-flying albatross. Fire co-ordination was difficult with other ships, as many ships 'locked on' to the same target with the result that other planes went through the system. Only missiles on the actual launching were operational; all others remained cool and inert in the ship's magazine. Also, the ship lay open to subsequent waves of attacking aircraft when reloads required a horrifying two minutes to warm up their gyros.

Deficiencies might have been foreseen and corrected in the planned *Sea Dart* modernization programme. Mr Nott's cuts, however, did not include scheduling the system for modernization, the lack of which led *Navy International* to conclude before the Falklands crisis that, 'the *Sheffield*-class will be unable to cope with the kinds of threats that may be encountered in the second half of the decade.'[3] Still, *Sea Dart* was expected to do something that her design did not allow. In addition to the lack of land-based airborne warning and control systems (AWACS) and fighters, the Type 42 *Sea Dart*-armed destroyers were deployed as radar pickets in exposed vanguard positions. All three Type 42s acting as pickets were hit: HMS *Sheffield* and HMS *Coventry* were sunk, and HMS *Glasgow* miraculously escaped destruction when a bomb passed through both sides of the ship. Finally, when assessing the effectiveness of shipborne aerial defence systems a 'kill' ratio of 50 per cent is considered to be high.

The ship that carried *Sea Dart*, the Type 42 destroyer, has been criticized for being under-armed. The 4,000-ton ship, which cost £85 million to build and £150 million to replace, was compared unfavourably by *Navy International* to the Soviet *Krivak*-class whose size is comparable.[4] Indeed, many cost reductions in addition to *Sea Dart* modernization have made the Type 42 a less capable ship. The most important of these reductions, the 30 per cent decrease in ship size, precluded the addition of the highly capable *Sea Wolf* anti-missile missile system. Pending the final decision to employ the light-weight *Sea Wolf* programme, consideration will be given to the addition of a different point missile system such as the NATO *Sea Sparrow* or a terminal defence like the *Vulcan Phalanx* gun both as quick fixes and long-term alternatives.

The unique British Aerospace *Sea Wolf* missile is extremely fast and extremely accurate, but it occupies so much space that it can only be deployed on specially-built ships. At present it is only deployed on the Type 22 *Broadsword*-class frigate. Two of these ships were in the Task Force and later supplemented by some *Leander* frigates. These ships survived repeated air attacks and brought down a large number of the planes that attacked them. They are only effective, however, in protecting other ships when they are placed between the attacking missile and the ship to be protected. The US Navy has been aware of *Sea Wolf* for the last eight years, but has not serviced a comparable system because of the system's large size and its inability to be deployed on older vessels. Thus, both the US Navy and the Royal Navy have chosen the *Phalanx* system, which has recently been deployed on the carrier HMS *Illustrious* and the Type 42 destroyer HMS *Newcastle*. British Aerospace is proposing a 'bolt on' system with a new light-weight radar system by Marconi. The government has supported the system so far, but it is uncertain, given the costs of *Trident* and 'Fortress Falklands', whether such a programme will be realized.

Not only has the Ministry of Defence delayed ship-borne missile programmes, but it has apparently rejected a proposal for updating electronic counter-measures on board the Task Force's ships. Used in conjunction with the largely manually-operated Abbey Hill electronic counter-measures system, the proposed modifications might have been able to jam the guidance radar of the *Exocet* missile. Also, the Royal Navy will have to assess the importance of 'chaff' – thin metal strips fired from small calibre guns to deflect the radar waves of a missile from its target.

The importance of submarines

The Falklands experience demonstrated the importance of submarines; the fear of British submarines after the sinking of the *Belgrano* kept the Argentinian navy bottled up in port. However, the primary importance of nuclear submarines is anti-submarine warfare. There could have been holes in Britain's submarine-enforced blockade; the World War II vintage *Santa Fe* penetrated through to South Georgia before it was caught on the surface. In another incident following the attack on HMS *Sheffield*, a frigate launched a torpedo attack against a suspected enemy submarine.

There may be lessons here for the US Navy as well. Cdr. John L. Byron of the US Naval Institute states that 'a carrier's ASW protection often resembles Swiss cheese.'[5] Admiral Hyman Rickover predicted that a carrier would last only two days in an all-out war. Unlike *Exocet*, which hits above the water line, a torpedo holes below it making a ship extremely difficult to keep afloat. Wire-guided torpedoes ensure that submarine attacks will be effective. Although some argue that a battleship could withstand both missile and torpedo attacks, reactivating these ships, in the words of Senator Goldwater, 'is like trying to renew the army by digging up General Custer.'[6] The Falklands conflict showed that all surface ships are vulnerable, and in the future, the US Navy must cushion the possibility of losses by building more ships. Large specialized ships may be survivable, but if temporarily put out of action, they are as good as sunk for the remainder of the battle; smaller ships might sink, but money saved will enable her sister ships to continue fighting.

Ship design

An investigation must not only include why the ships were hit but what happened to them afterwards. The Type-21 frigates were fitted with all the latest fire-fighting equipment including sprinkler systems and fire-proof hatches and doors. The Royal Navy trains regularly and is considered extremely proficient in damage control situations; yet the ship burned. Naval experts are quick to attribute the fire to the use of aluminium. Although half the weight of steel plate, aluminium melts at 700°C compared to 1,500°C for steel. Experts are speculating that the next generation of warships, including the Royal Navy's Type 23 frigate, will revert to steel; however, aluminium should not be too hastily condemned. Aluminium enables ships to be smaller, faster, and armed with more weapons systems, and prevents ships from becoming top heavy and unstable: steel would necessitate large ships which would be extremely expensive and perhaps unstable.

The key question is whether aluminium was the main reason why the ships burned and then sank. In World War II, the Japanese launched the biggest and most armoured battleship, the *Yamato*, yet, a series of aerial torpedoes and bombs sent the vessel to the bottom of the

Pacific. The point is that even though the next generation of ships is made of steel, sea-skimming missiles, like the *Exocet*, may still sink ships. Despite a missile's rather small warhead of only about 300 pounds, the sheer kinetic energy produced by a 13-cwt missile striking at near supersonic speeds would be enough to start fires and devastate a target. In addition to the power of the warhead, the presence of high explosive and unused propellant contribute to, and further explain, the damages suffered by the HMS *Sheffield*. The key lesson here is that surface ships operating alone without adequate air cover are vulnerable.

Fire fighting aboard these ships was made difficult by the thick choking smoke, probably caused by the burning of electrical insulation made from polyvinylchloride (PVC). Testing of target vessels involves the stripping of all electrical wiring so the choking smoke was not accounted for. Also, test target ships are drained of useable fuel and ammunition; the fuel is particularly hazardous, because gas turbine vessels run on a highly flammable mixture similar to the aviation fuel called JP5. The Type 21-class, which included *Ardent* and *Antelope*, had previous fire problems which the modifications to companion-ways greatly reduced. Newly constructed ships must use modern materials and in particular materials similar to chobham armour or keylar for protective covering of vital parts.

Aircraft and air defence

One of the bright spots of the campaign was the effectiveness of the *Harriers*. Although they performed extremely well, they were fighting while operating at the limits of their range. The *Mirages* rarely utilized their supersonic capabilities because of the drain it placed upon fuel consumption; travelling at supersonic speeds caused their fuel consumption to rise from 200 to 400 litres per minute. There were very few dog fights and most of the Argentinian aircraft were downed by *Sidewinder* missiles. Though the *Harrier* pilots performed brilliantly, often having only two minutes to react to enemy aircraft and spending up to 10 hours in the cockpits, pilot degradation resulting from a large number of sorties should be looked into.

The operational maintenance and readiness of the *Harrier* aircraft was another highlight of the campaign. Indeed, the unsung heroes of the campaign are the *Harrier* ground crews, who kept the aircraft flying 90 per cent of the time.[7] This is in sharp contrast to figures published in the *Armed Forces Journal* which indicated that the AV-8A was not mission capable 39·7 per cent of the time.[8] The effectiveness of the *Harrier*'s ground attack capabilities has been confirmed by the war, but it is emerging that it is a less effective weapon when attacking hardened targets such as airfields. The *Harriers* were inadequately armed, as the Jp233 anti-airfield bomb is not in service, and the *Harrier*'s range was reduced by its heavy ordinance. Lack of reconnaissance aircraft further reduced effectiveness, and cloud cover obstructed American spy satellites. These last two conditions meant that most *Harrier* raids were conducted against military installations around the airfield rather than against the airstrip itself. Although they dropped cluster bombs along the runway, effecting destruction of the surrounding ground and parked aircraft, the Argentinians were still able to fly *Hercules* transports into Port Stanley.

While much has been said about the effectiveness of AWACS, one must still wonder whether a subsonic *Harrier* could take on supersonic aircraft in the North Atlantic. Although AWACS could have helped the British in the South Atlantic, it does not transform the *Harrier* into a conventional fighter. While the *Harrier* can play an important role in NATO air defence, its performance does not detract from the importance of F-15, F-16, or *Tornado* aircraft. The lack of AWACS was, nevertheless, a serious deficiency, and a heliborne system should be designed; indeed, Britain should consider looking into the US Navy's research project concerning V/STOL AWACS.

The *Vulcan* raids were also ineffective. Though the first raid on 1 May dropped most of the 21 1,000-lb bombs on the runway, the second raid was a near miss as bombs fell to one side of the runway. The Royal Air Force (RAF) has a laser-guided system which could have turned the munitions into 'smart' bombs as achieved in Vietnam, but such accuracy would have necessitated a second aircraft to illuminate the target. Also, the RAF did not have enough *Victor* tanks to refuel more than one *Vulcan* at a time on such a long sortie and still maintain their safety margin, as the flight from Ascension Island to the airfield target was 4,000 miles, and three *Victors* were necessary on a single aircraft raid. Though it is possible for one of these tankers to refuel another over an extended distance, had the Falkland Islands been closer to the Argentinian mainland, the refuelling process may have been intercepted by the *Mirage*.

The failure to destroy the airfield at Port Stanley and the need for RAF *Phantoms* illustrates the importance of adequate air strategy. This strategy may be difficult to formulate due to the inter-service squabbles which will occur. Since the Royal Air Force had the least important role to play in the conflict, their political power within the Ministry of Defence may be diminished. Thus, they may be the prime candidate for future cuts in the defence budget. This would be disastrous, as Britain needs a flexible air force with the capabilities of performing a number of roles. Should future aircraft development programmes be cut, the RAF will be left only with *Tornado*. This is an excellent interdiction aircraft, but it is not an aerial superiority fighter.

Although the *Tornado* will perform air defence, ground attack is more worrying. The AV8B is of great assistance but is not as effective as the A-10 tank attacker. Effective strategy will often require the elimination of airfields early in a conflict; however, the results of attacks on the Stanley airfield show how durable they can be. More attention must focus on rendering airfields inoperable; conversely, proper airfield defence must be maintained. Effective airfield defence would necessitate not only technologically advanced and properly maintained conventional arms, but possession of in-depth knowledge on the use of this equipment in planned strategies. In the Falkland Islands, the *Rapiers* performed well, but the men had no practice in dealing with this anti-aircraft missile system until it had reached Ascension Island.

In addition to the need for training with weapons systems in a time when technology compensates for numerical deficiencies, missile systems must be mobile and among the first priorities of a landing force. For example, the disaster at Bluff Cove was caused in part by the inoperability of the *Rapier* detachment. Because *Rapier* was not mobile, it was unable to keep up with advancing forces. Troops were forced to rely on *Blowpipe*, a shoulder mounted surface-to-air missile with a range of 2½ miles. *Blowpipe* proved effective in the Falklands, but its success might not be repeated on the Central Front where a soldier firing it would expose himself to enemy fire. This exposure was not an obstacle in the Falklands, however, where most Argentinian troops were holed up in garrisons. Although the Falklands experience has highlighted the importance of precision-guided munitions, we must be careful not to delude ourselves into thinking that they are a replacement for armoured fighting vehicles and fixed air defence positions. The Central Front with its waves of Soviet tanks would be very different from the actions which took place on the Falkland Islands.

Intangibles: weather and training

For those who are tempted to see modern warfare as nothing more than a contest between rival electronic systems, the campaign has been a sobering reminder of the awesome power of the elements and the will of the infantryman. Despite the use of sophisticated hardware, the weather has dictated when the helicopter could operate, when the *Harrier* could attack, and when the Argentinian *Skyhawks* could launch their devastating attacks. Cloud cover allowed 5 Brigade to leap-frog into Fitzroy, but when it lifted, the Argentinians could attack the warships. Although many overlooked the Argentinian winter, the climate should not have been underestimated. The Falklands are not particularly cold, but the Royal Marines considered conditions there far more dangerous than in the Arctic. Unpredictable weather, sunshine, mist and snowstorms, coupled with rain and wind, combined to make good conditions for exposure. In addition, the Falkland Islands' rough terrain and cold, damp conditions sometimes caused the normal marching pace of 4 mph to decrease by half.

According to one journalist, the Royal Marines were better prepared for the elements than was the army. The Guards battalions had spent many months on ceremonial duties and very few on movement and survival in marginal conditions; they were not considered fit enough to march across the island in the same fashion as the Royal Marines and the Paras. The confusion and difficulty that arose from using a brigade with so little experience in working together and in warfare in adverse conditions showed how invaluable to the campaign the Commando brigade had been. Without them, this operation would have been unthinkable. Indeed, the Special Air Service (SAS), Special Boat Section (SBS) and commandos fought a 'war' for which they had been trained – carrying out a series of successful raids on enemy airfields and positions, and playing an important role in obtaining intelligence and reconnaissance, especially when cloud cover prevented US spy satellites from operating reliably.

The British troops have once again earned the title of 'best trained, worst equipped'. It is in the hard climatic conditions of the Falklands that the training, self discipline and *esprit de corps*, inculcated into the British army, come into play. Invaluable also, was the experience in Northern Ireland, where NCOs learned to take unprecedented responsibility and soldiers discovered the difference between the 'let's pretend' of exercises and the reality of war.

Mobilization and logistics

Many lessons have been learned by the Ministry of Defence and by its industrial contractors. The contractors kept the Navy at a very high state of readiness. Contingency plans for the mobilization of the merchant marine worked well. In liaison with the Department of Trade, defence officials picked out suitable merchant ships, from trawlers to the *Queen Elizabeth II*, chartered or commandeered them, and then often had surveyors on board to plan for the fitting of helicopter pads or other conversions before the vessels had even reached their home ports. Meticulous preplanning also took care of ensuring that the right stores and equipment were transported in the specified quantities and loaded in the correct order. Cargo dispersal, however, was a problem. Specialized ships were used to transport a single item, but high priority items should have been dispersed among many ships so that a single item would not be completely destroyed. When the *Atlantic Conveyor* was hit, it carried many helicopters and a large quantity of tents; these and similar items should have been divided among several ships.

Despite the fine record of the Ministry of Defence, problems nevertheless occurred. The portable airfield is still awaiting shipment in Southampton, and the first deployment of *Rapier* was only made in the optical mode, owing to an administrative error which prevented some of its logistical equipment from arriving on time. The conflict also showed that the Ministry of Defence can move with speed, if it must, to arm planes with *Sidewinder* and refuelling probes.

The British arms industry learnt some lessons from the mobilization too. Perhaps the key task facing British Aerospace was converting *Nimrod* aircraft for inflight refuelling; in peacetime, this task might have required two years of wrestling with red tape. Despite the fact that British Aerospace was trying to maintain spares, the conversion of the *Nimrod* was completed in three weeks. Many other firms cleared their decks and put their work force on overtime to keep up with MoD orders and provide emergency deliveries of equipment and materiel.

The overall picture is that both British industry and the Ministry of Defence have responded quickly and efficiently to the Falklands crisis and its need for extra supplies. The conflict underscores the importance of defence industries maintaining operations in peacetime as assembly lines may be hard to restart if left idle for years. The government must form a comprehensive policy to keep assembly lines open other than for selling arms abroad. (If anything, the crisis has shown the danger of indiscriminate arms sales. Prior to the outbreak of hostilities, Britain was one of Argentina's best suppliers. Unfortunately, some of the equipment was used against our forces during the conflict.)

The Future of British Defence Policy

When World War II ended, Britain was hardly a super-power, in spite of the vast territory she still controlled. The next three decades witnessed her more or less voluntary disengagement from a world role to that of a regional power of the second rank, concentrating on NATO and the EEC in her defence and foreign policy roles. It was not a complete withdrawal; the extent of Britain's global commitments remain in the form of a military presence in Hong Kong, Belize, Gibraltar, Cyprus, Brunei, Diego Garcia, and in the form of a naval presence in the West Indies and Indian Ocean. The military presence in the Falkland Islands consisted of a company of marines until the beginning of April.

The process of the disengagement was neither as rational nor as disorderly as some people indicate.[9] It was in a way an attempt to come to terms with the fact that *commitments* exceeded *resources*, a grotesque disparity which Britain managed to conceal from subjects abroad for most of the nineteenth century. Duncan Sandys in the late 1950s and the Labour Party in the 1960s and 1970s tried various solutions which together were not completely successful in narrowing this gap between commitments and resources. The latest Tory defence review, though not called that by Conservatives, is yet another attempt in this continuing process.

The post-war period has thus been one of both continuity and change. Military manpower fell from 825,000 in 1951 to about 330,000 today. Defence spending has fallen as a percentage of total public expenditure in the same period from about 25 per cent to around 10 per cent, but defence spending as a percentage of GDP has remained fairly constant – just below 5 per cent in 1981 – well above that spent by France, Germany and all the NATO allies except the US (and Greece). It would be wrong to argue that the quality of the contribution to NATO has diminished: indeed, support for the concept of alliance and commitment of resources is high. This commitment of Britain is a contribution to NATO in four areas: the Eastern Atlantic, the Central region, defence of the home base, and strategic deterrence in the form of a flotilla of SSBN submarines carrying *Polaris* missiles.

Britain has maintained her four NATO commitments with considerable difficulty, despite her relatively unsuccessful economic performance, competing domestic priorities, and a huge escalation in equipment and manpower costs. The combination of the Falklands situation, adding appreciably to the defence budget (though fortunately not to the Ministry of Defence budget), and the decision to procure a successor system to the *Polaris* force, will pose major resource allocation problems; the maintenance of the existing commitments at the current level of effectiveness will be possible only with a considerably increased budget. When the present Government entered office, it was with a manifesto pledge that 'significant increases will be necessary'. The rhetoric has not been easy to translate into reality; even the 3 per cent annual real increase has proven troublesome.

The Trident programme

But if coping with the existing programme will be difficult, adding *Trident* will make it even more so. The decision, finally announced to Parliament on 15 July 1980 and justified in the Defence Open Government Document (DOGD 80/23) and to Parliament and its Defence Committee many times, has been spelled out once again in the opening of the recent White Paper. Initially, it was decided that the *Trident* I (C4) missile would be purchased, but, principally in the interest of commonality with the United States, the decision was changed to purchase *Trident* II (D5) instead, and was announced on 11 March 1982 (DOGD 82/1).[10]

Opposition by some may be based on ethical, religious and philosophical grounds, but for others, the pro-defence yet anti-*Trident* case rests on its high costs and on its consequences for the remainder of the defence budget. The British Government's decision to procure a successor strategic deterrent based on the *Trident* missile system could necessitate a major alteration in its contribution to NATO. From available evidence, much of it submitted by the Government to the Defence Committee, it would appear to some that Britain cannot both acquire the *Trident* force envisaged *and* maintain her current commitment in the other areas of her NATO contributions to EASTLANT, AFCENT, and the UK Home Base.

This view was most forcibly argued in the Minority Report of the Defence Committee: 'We are greatly concerned with the opportunity costs such a purchase would represent in terms of new equipment possibilities lost and of planned equipment programmes cancelled... We feel additional money could be very usefully spent in improving the so-called "teeth" of existing forces – for example, in strengthening the air defence of the UK – and the so-called "tail" of existing forces... We are greatly concerned that the acquisition of *Trident* could have adverse affects on the quality of our conventional weapon contribution to NATO and on the morale of our forces.'[11]

Even the Conservative Majority Report which approved the Government's decision had some qualifications and doubts: 'Against the background of current reviews of defence commitments and expenditure, however, it is very difficult to see how it will be possible to give top priority to the *Trident* programme throughout the decade without something else being squeezed out, unless economic conditions improve drastically.'[12]

John Nott, in his White Paper 'The United Kingdom Defence Programme: The Way Forward', published a year ago, has argued that *Trident* can be accommodated without significant diminution in conventional capability. In the current 'Statement on the Defence Estimates 1982', published on 22 June 1982 (though printed in March before the Falkland crisis), he shows how this can be done. Not everyone was convinced, even then; the Shadow Defence Spokesman argued that Mr Nott had done it by mirrors or 'like a conjuror concealing by illusion what is really happening to the defence effort.'[13]

In the best analysis of the 'reshaping' (Conservatives do not cut) of Britain's defences, David Greenwood writes:

> 'Decisions have been taken to *reduce* front line forces and the strengths of the Services, together with the supporting infrastructure of defence. The new model programme – for that is what it is – embodies provision significantly different from that in the old for fulfilment of three of the major tasks to which the national defence is directed. Contraction in the the scope of naval and military dispositions, and transformation in the character of some of them are foreshadowed.'[14]

The Government simply did not have the resources, and are not likely to obtain them, to sustain its defence commitments and aspirations. To maintain 'balanced' forces – what one politician called maintaining Britain as a scaled-down version of the American military – has left British conventional forces stretched to their limits. While even without *Trident*, the defence budget was under pressure, spending on *Trident*, even spread over 15 years, will make matters even more difficult. Mr Nott has argued repeatedly that it will require 3 per cent of the budget, but it could represent as high as 20–25 per cent of the new equipment budget. The principal victim of the Nott 'adjustments' was to be the Navy. By 1985–6 the number of escorts was to be reduced to 75 per cent of the pre-Falklands total (from 66 in mid-1981 to 44 in the mid-1980s), the *Invincible* was to be sold, and the docklands were to be closed.

The future of the Royal Navy

Though the Admirals fought and lost and the Junior Navy Minister was dismissed for opposing Government military proposals, both maintained the fight in public and private. It was ironic that a number of the Task Force that set sail, as well as some of the sailors, were scheduled for sale, scrap, mothballs or unemployment. Lord Hill Norton, former Chief of Defence Staff and Admiral of the Fleet, wrote in the aftermath of the victory:

> Make no mistake, we were able to deal with this problem effectively because we were living off the fat of the pre-1981 Defence Review. In two years time that fat would have been cut off and we should have been unable to mount such an operation. There is a distinct possibility we would have been defeated had we attempted it.[15]

If the Argentinians had waited for the consequences of Defence Secretary Nott's cuts, 'They might', in the words of General Sir John Hackett, former commander of NATO's Northern Army Group, 'have gotten away with it.'[16] Without *Intrepid* and *Fearless*, which were recently saved from the scrap yard, with *Invincible* due to be sold to Australia, and with *Antrim* and *Glamorgan* due to be withdrawn, an amphibious operation on a large scale would have been difficult, if not impossible, to perform.

The 'war' has given the Navy the opportunity to restate its case, not only for the replacement of its lost ships, but for a considerable increase in the pre-review figures to save the doomed dockyards, to cancel the sale of the *Invincible* to Australia, to implement obviously needed defences against air attack, and to restore to the Navy its extra NATO dimension.

The size of the Navy after the Falklands nevertheless remains uncertain. Prior to the conflict, the government ordered only 4 of the 27 warships planned for the Navy between 1979 and 1987, and its expenditure on naval shipbuilding is only half that achieved by the previous Labour government. Secretary Nott's defence review cut the Navy by one third, envisioning 42 active and 8 reserve ships. In light of its post Falklands victory, the Navy is asking for 100 ships, but will settle for 70; however, Mr Nott appears to be offering only 50 active vessels. The Navy is also advocating that an expensive Type 22-style ship be the backbone of its post Falklands shipbuilding programme instead of an austere Type 23 vessel which costs half as much. The Navy's chances of obtaining the Type 22 vessel prior to the Falklands were slim, but now, after the vessel and its *Sea Wolf* missile had a 'good war', the Navy is hoping that the government will agree to an only-the-best-will-do policy. The Navy must realize, however, that the present cost of the Type 23 utility frigate is expected to exceed its cost parameter of £60 million and, therefore, could not afford to accommodate even the light-weight *Sea Wolf* system.

The lack of communication among the naval staff, the ship designers in Bath, and the Ministry of Defence is a major reason why unrealistic proposals exist. Several factors make communication difficult: the naval Junior staff officers are totally unschooled in the Civil Service system which dominates the Ministry of Defence, much of the naval staff's time and effort is spent on minor issues rather than on the formulation of naval strategy, the Ship Department is located in Bath, and the Ministry of Defence is so torn with interservice strife that realistic policy formulation is difficult, if not impossible.[17] The Navy has always been hard hit in the struggles of policy-making because the costs of its weapons systems, the submarines for example, are so enormously high.

Trident and the retirement of older submarines will put a tremendous strain on British underseas forces. Plans by the government to increase the number of nuclear hunter-killer submarines show on examination to be essentially a continuation of long-term plans laid down in the mid-1970s. Although Vickers claims that they could turn out one *Trafalgar*-class submarine every 12 months, there is no indication that the rate of ordering will be increased; two more remain to be ordered and a seventh has been dropped. Submarines presently under construction or on order are unlikely to be completed before the late 1980s, by which time older SSN like *Dreadnought*, *Valiant* and *Warspite* will have to be retired. By 1990, the Royal Navy submarine force is likely to number no more than 15 and of these, 5 or 6 at any time will be undergoing refits. If 3 submarines are stationed in the Falklands, then only about 7 will be available for NATO patrol. There is no indication that the SSN production line at Cammel Laird's Birkenhead shipyard, mothballed for the past 10 years, will be reopened; without such a facility, the building of 4 *Trident* submarines at Vickers Barrows will preclude SSN construction in Britain until 1992.

Implications for NATO

As much as Britain can learn from the Falklands, the implications for NATO are far greater. The revised British defence policy was a break from the past. Since World War II, Britain attempted to maintain a balanced force designed primarily for NATO and almost exclusively for NATO after the withdrawal from East of Suez. For years, the increasing cost of weapons systems was stretching the balanced line extremely thin. Last year major holes emerged in this line, as the surface fleet was cut by one-third and the Royal Navy concentrated on underwater forces. The new policy did consider extra-territorial contingencies, but operations in those areas are eccentric to any role that British forces will have in the future. The consequences of a smaller fleet deployed in a larger ocean area would be a severe reduction of Britain's role in the North Atlantic, though the primary defence contingency must continue to be NATO. Britain's large contribution to NATO was one of the major reasons for EEC support throughout the crisis.

What is essential is that we do not allow the Falklands to distort our primary strategy. Because of the costs of maintaining a Falklands garrison and *Trident*, many people are saying that British forces in Germany are an expensive anachronism, their contributions to the Alliance being of relatively little military importance and only of limited political leverage; thus, Britain should instead concentrate on a maritime strategy. Less extreme proponents concede the political-military value of some British troops and aircraft on the continent of Europe, but see no reason why they should be so numerous or be committed forever to the defence of a particular length of front. The Brussels Treaty, however, commits Britain to 55,000 troops and a substantial Air Force in Germany, and though this treaty was concluded in the days of national service when the army was three times its present size, a partial abrogation could send shock waves through the Alliance. Damage to morale in the Western Alliance would probably be greater than that from any other single action. Gaps would have to be filled with German forces and this could possibly cause additional concerns.

Recognizing the major diplomatic and military problems which such withdrawals would cause, others advocate a radical reduction in Britain's Eastern Atlantic presence, to allow the fleet to be deployed in other areas. The arguments for this are (1) that no war in Europe will last long enough for seaborne reinforcement; (2) that the US Navy is powerful enough; and (3) that protection of the Northern Flank amphibious forces is unnecessary in peacetime and suicidal in war. But the short war scenario is risky to plan for, as it assumes a rapid escalation towards the brink of nuclear warfare. This scenario also contradicts the protracted war strategy which was recently introduced by NATO. As for the US Navy, it was already overburdened by previous global commitments and was severely taxed by additional deployments in the North Atlantic during the Falklands campaign. A naval presence in the Eastern Atlantic is not only important in wartime, but also in the grey area leading up to a conflict. In other words, the Royal Navy acts as a deterrent against any kind of aggression in the Eastern Atlantic. The removal or drastic reduction of the British maritime effort in the Eastern Atlantic would leave a dangerous void, particularly in the critical period at the outbreak of hostilities. Finally, no other NATO navy can replace the Royal Navy in the Eastern Atlantic where it provides 80 per cent of the forces.

In many European nations, any proposal that naval expenditure be increased to compensate for a British policy of retrenchment would fall on deaf ears. By the same token, the Air Force cannot be cut for it is essential to NATO security. Maritime long-range strike aircraft are also important, and, of course, aerial tankers are essential. However, given the Falklands crisis and *Trident*, it will be impossible to maintain a balanced force. Rationalization may be an answer, but such discussions must be made within the Alliance structure. If the decisions are made in a dual Imperialist and Gaullist fashion, then the Alliance will be severely damaged.

NOTES

[1] For a study of the Defence Committee, see George, B. and Pieragostini, K. 'The Making of British Defence Policy: A Role Again for the House of Commons', a paper presented to the American Political Science Association, New York, September 1981.

[2] Quoted in *Newsweek*, 17 May 1982, p. 39.

[3] *Navy International*, October 1981, p. 602.

[4] *Ibid.*

[5] Quoted in *Newsweek*, 17 May 1982, p. 39.

[6] 'Are Big Ships Vulnerable?', *Newsweek*, 3 May 1982.

[7] John Nott, Statement Before the Select Committee on Defence, 23 June 1982.

[8] As cited by James Fallows in his *National Defense* (NY: Random House, 1981), p. 41.

[9] For author's view, see Bruce, George and Pieragostini, K. 'British Defence in the 1980s: What Price Trident?', *International Security Review*, Vol. V, No. IV, Winter 1980–81.

[10] House of Commons, 4th Report from the Defence Committee Session 1980–81, *Strategic Nuclear Weapons Policy*, 26 May 1981; and 1st Report Session 1981–82, *Strategic Nuclear Weapons Policy.*

[11] 'The First Special Report from the Defence Committee', 21 April 1982, HC 266-I.

[12] 'The Fourth Report of the Defence Committee', 20 May 1981, p. xxii.

[13] *The United Kingdom Defence Programme: The Way Forward*, Cmnd 8288, June 1981.

[14] David Greenwood, 'Reshaping Britain's Defences', *Aberdeen Studies in Defence Economics*, No. 19, Summer 1981.

[15] The *Mail on Sunday* (London), 20 June 1982.

[16] General Sir John Hackett, 'Britain Must Spend More on Conventional Defence', *Sunday Times* (London), 20 June 1982.

[17] John Moore, 'Is small beautiful? Is cheap nasty?', *RUSI Journal*, September 1981, pp. 33–4.